

A Virginia Win
As Democrats
Bare Knuckles

Party Embraces Tactics
It Once Opposed

By **KELLEN BROWNING**

Democrats' success in pushing through one of the country's most aggressively gerrymandered congressional maps on Tuesday in Virginia represented the latest example of the party's willingness to take the gloves off as it seeks to win back control of Congress and thwart President Trump's agenda. It was a stark reversal for a party that has decried partisan gerrymandering for years. But Democrats said that the new map, which could flip as many as four Republican-held seats, was necessary to counter similar G.O.P. efforts in Texas and other states. Their new mantra: It's time to play hardball. "While many expected Democrats to roll over and play dead, we did the opposite," Hakeem Jeffries, the House Democratic leader from New York, said in a statement after The Associated Press called the race. "Democrats did not step back. We fought back. When they go low, we hit back hard."

The party's newly combative approach extends beyond redistricting as it has felt a new urgency to regain power in Washington. Despite their qualms over dark money, Democrats are nowadays more reliant on it than Republicans. And on Capitol Hill, they have adopted an uncompromising approach to spending negotiations, forcing a partial government shutdown earlier this year after they refused to fund immigration enforcement operations without new restrictions on federal agents' tactics. It all amounts to a new openness among Democrats — spurred on by constituents demanding more forceful opposition to Mr. Trump — to reverse their opposition to political tactics they once considered bad governance. None have been more head-spinning than the Virginia gerrymander, which transforms a nearly evenly divided 11-member congressional delegation into one with only one sure Republican seat. Proponents framed the initiative as a less than ideal but necessary rebuttal to a gerrymandering war started by Republicans. The

Continued on Page A13

SLICED Both parties are splitting urban areas to eke out a partisan advantage. The julienned districts have little in common. **PAGE A14**

Influencers, Rebuffing Doctors,
Push a 'Natural' Elixir: Nicotine

By **DANI BLUM**

There's a compound that can reverse Alzheimer's, increase cognitive function and potentially even help you live longer, Dave Asprey, a biohacking influencer, has told his million-plus social media followers. The wonder drug? Nicotine, Mr. Asprey claims.



LANNA APISUKH FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Nicotine pouches are among the products being promoted.



KIANA HAYERI FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Leaving Home, and Loved Ones, as Iran's Economy Falters

At Turkey's Kapikoy crossing on Wednesday, Iranian parents said goodbye to a family that had received a work visa for Australia.

Hospice Fraud
Is a Flashpoint
For California

By **SOUMYA KARLAMANGLA**

SAN FRANCISCO — Hospice fraud in California has been remarkably brazen. Medicare recipients have been signed up for care without their knowledge by thieves who stole their identities. Providers have paid kickbacks to people to enroll even though they aren't terminally ill and don't qualify. Sham companies have fabricated lists of employees. The schemes have been an irresistible political target for President Trump, who mentioned California as a top offender when he created a task force last month to root out corruption in federally funded programs. He said that he believed that fraud in the nation's most populous state was "10 times worse" than anywhere else. But long before Mr. Trump weighed in, state investigators had uncovered rampant fraud in California's hospice system on their own. For years, state and federal officials had been taking steps to combat abuses, and the state has

Continued on Page A20

Long Year of Struggle for Fired U.S.A.I.D. Staff

By **ELISABETH BUMILLER**
and **EILEEN SULLIVAN**

WASHINGTON — She was fired by email while on maternity leave, given 24 hours to clear out her desk and left with three days of health insurance and no severance pay. She had worked for the U.S. Agency for International Development or related groups for more than two decades. She made \$175,000 a year. That was Jan. 28, 2025. Today Amy Uccello and her husband, who also lost his job when U.S.A.I.D. funding for his nonprofit dried up, rely on food stamps, Medicaid and a supplemental nutrition program for women and

**Toll Felt in Entire Field
as Careers, Savings
and Hopes Vanish**

children that helps with their now 19-month-old daughter. The mortgage on their home in Washington was until recently in forbearance, meaning they negotiated to pay less than they owed each month. But the bank has now cut them off and suggested they apply for a low-income mortgage program. "We don't know if we'll qualify," Ms. Uccello said. She and her husband have applied for

more than 100 jobs with no luck. Most of their friends don't have jobs either. Nights are the hardest. "I can't sleep because of our own situation," Ms. Uccello, 49, said over coffee on a recent afternoon. "I can't sleep because of what I know what's happening around the world. I can't sleep because my former colleagues and friends are also suffering." When the Trump administration dismantled the sprawling global aid agency last year, it wiped out virtually an entire industry — international development — that had been based in Washington since U.S.A.I.D.'s creation. *Continued on Page A18*



"I never even once imagined I would be so betrayed by my government," said Adrian Mathura, a veteran and a former U.S.A.I.D. adviser.



Jacqueline Devine, 66, who used to work in sub-Saharan Africa on H.I.V. treatment, now relies on a \$9,000 income from teaching.

Clashes Over Civil Rights Group's 'Hate' Labels Preceded Charges

By **RICHARD FAUSSET**

For much of the 21st century, the Southern Poverty Law Center has been at the center of a bitter partisan war in America over what constitutes hate. The law center, which is based in Alabama, began in 1971, earning a reputation for battling the Ku Klux Klan in court and helping reporters and law enforcement keep tabs on far-right domestic extremists. More recently, however, the S.R.L.C. has earned the ire of conservatives by criticizing a number of organizations — including Moms For Liberty, the Family Research Council and Turning Point USA — that many on the right consider to be squarely within the American mainstream. The conflict entered a new phase this week, when the Justice Department charged the S.P.L.C. with a number of financial crimes, including wire fraud and conspiracy to commit money laundering. The indictment focused on the law center's past use of paid inform-

ants to infiltrate far-right groups. Todd Blanche, the acting attorney general, accused the group of "manufacturing racism to justify its existence." To some who have been criticized by the S.P.L.C., it was a moment to savor — a potential comeuppance for what they perceive to

**Right Wing Saw Attack
on the Mainstream**

be a powerful, politically correct bully that has sought to shame and silence legitimate voices. "Well, I mean, obviously I experienced a certain schadenfreude, because this couldn't happen to a nicer bunch of creeps," said Mark Krikorian, executive director of the Center for Immigration Studies, a group that supports immigration restrictions and has been on the S.P.L.C.'s influential list of hate groups for years. The S.P.L.C. defines a hate *Continued on Page A17*

NATIONAL A12-21

F.B.I. Inquiry Into Writer

The agency is said to have investigated a New York Times reporter after she wrote about the girlfriend of the bureau's director, Kash Patel. **PAGE A20**

Lifeline for Renewable Energy

A judge halted the Trump administration's efforts to throttle wind and solar projects across the country. **PAGE A16**

OBITUARIES B10-11

From Bodybuilder to Artist

Paul Waldman turned from muscles to making subversive paintings and an art museum for birds. He was 89. **PAGE B10**

INTERNATIONAL A4-11

Afghans May Head to Africa

President Trump is said to be in talks to send to Congo a group of Afghans who helped U.S. forces in the war. **PAGE A11**

For Prisoners, a Welcome Hand

Sugey Amaya, whose brother is jailed in El Salvador, helps inmates who are given a chance to go free. **PAGE A6**



BUSINESS B1-5

Trying to Shed 'Puppet' Label

Kevin Warsh, at his confirmation hearing to lead the Fed, sought to dispel doubts he would yield to President Trump's demand for lower rates. **PAGE B1**

Mars or the Moon or A.I.?

As SpaceX readies an I.P.O., Elon Musk has proposed different goals from the original aim of reaching Mars. **PAGE B1**

THURSDAY STYLES D1-6

Two Brothers, Many Feuds

For years, Prajit and Projjal Dutta have led the market for South Asian art in the U.S. Now, they are at odds. **PAGE D4**

ARTS C1-6

Listening to Both Sides

At twice-monthly gatherings in Brooklyn, people listen to entire albums, the old-fashioned way, on vinyl. **PAGE C1**

Playing the Part So Well

Krysten Ritter dons the black leather jacket again as the character Jessica Jones in a "Daredevil" series. **PAGE C1**



SPORTS B6-9, 12

N.F.L. Scouts' High-Tech Tools

To prepare for the draft, teams once relied on VCRs. Now they can sort mountains of data instantly. **PAGE B6**

Rocky, and Muddy, Ski Season

Little snow and warm weather forced some resorts to close early, but die-hards kept the party going. **PAGE B7**

OPINION A22-23

Jill Filipovic

PAGE A23

